Thomas J. Hughes

George Mason University
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EDUCATION:

Ph.D., Economics (ABD), George Mason University, Fairfax, VA — Expected 2027
M.A., Economics, George Mason University, Fairfax, VA — 2025
B.A., Mathematics and Economics, Mercer University, Macon, GA — 2023
Minor: Statistics; Certificate: Actuarial Science

Fields: Political Economy; Applied Microeconomics; Austrian Economics; Economic Sociology

FELLOWSHIPS AND AFFILIATIONS:

PhD Fellowship, Mercatus Center — 2023 – present
Graduate Fellow, F.A. Hayek Program for Advanced Study in Philosophy, Politics, and Economics, Mercatus Center — 2023 – present
Network Member, Initiative for the Study of a Stable Peace — 2024 – present

PROFESSIONAL WORK:

Graduate Lecturer, George Mason University — 2026 – present
Intermediate Microeconomics (ECON 306), one section
Graduate Teaching Assistant – Instructor of Record, George Mason University — 2025 – 2026
Contemporary Macroeconomic Principles (ECON 104), four sections
Course Evaluations: Fall 2025: Section 004; Section 008
Spring 2026: Section 001; Section 010
Graduate Research Assistant, George Mason University — 2023 – 2025; 2026 – present
Assistant for Christopher J. Coyne (2023–2025, 2026–2027) and Peter J. Boettke (Summer 2024)
Preceptor, Mercer University — 2020 – 2021
Calculus 1 preceptor classes, Department of Mathematics, four sections

ACADEMIC PUBLICATIONS:

1. Journal Articles

"Bureaucratic Control After *Loper Bright Enterprises v. Raimondo*: The Rise of Judicial Control in a Post-Chevron Deference World," *Journal of Public Finance and Public Choice*, 2026. doi: https://doi.org/10.1332/25156918Y2026D000000031

2. Under Review

"The Weapon Itself is the Threat: Nuclear Weapons, the Knowledge Problem, and Normal Accidents," under review at *Cosmos + Taxis*. (with C. Coyne)

3. Working Papers

"The Budget-Maximizing Peacemaker: The Success Paradox of Peace-Through-Strength Defense Policy"

"Does Government-Nonprofit Contracting Instantiate Democratic Priority-Setting?" (with B. Mandeville)

4. Works in Progress

"Centripetal and Centrifugal Forces in Single-Dimensional Computational Spatial Voting Models" (with R. Ragan)

"Doctoral Failure: A Subjectivist Model of Exploitative Medical Behavior under Moral Constraints"

"When Truth Can Be Bad for Business: A Theory of Expert Failure in Religious Leadership" (with R. Koppl)

"William Niskanen and the Economics of Bureaucracy: Theory, Influence, and Policy Legacy"

5. Books and Monographs in Progress
The Machinery of Administration: Bureaucracy in Mainline Economics. (with C. Coyne)

HONORS AND AWARDS:

Young Scholar, Association for Private Enterprise Education 2026
Student Fellow of the Public Choice Society 2026
Outstanding Award in Research, Stetson-Hatcher School of Business, Mercer University 2023
Center for the Study of Economics and Liberty Research Grant, Mercer University 2023

PROFESSIONAL SERVICE:

Referee: *Journal of Public Finance and Public Choice*

INVITED ACADEMIC PRESENTATIONS:

Mercer University, Center for the Study of Economics and Liberty September 2026
Macon, Georgia. "Peace Doesn't Pay: The Success Paradox of Defense Bureaucracy"

CONFERENCES:

Association of Private Enterprise Education Meeting, Las Vegas, NV April 2026
Presented: "The Budget-Maximizing Peacemaker" & "The Weapon Itself is the Threat"
Public Choice Society, San Antonio, TX March 2026
Presented: "The Budget-Maximizing Peacemaker"
Southern Economic Association, Tampa, FL November 2025
Presented: "Bureaucratic Control After *Loper Bright*" & "Doctoral Failure"
Markets and Society Conference, Falls Church, VA October 2025
Presented: "The Weapon Itself is the Threat"
Society of Business, Industry, and Economics, Destin, FL April 2023
Presented: "Centripetal and Centrifugal Forces in Spatial Voting Models"

REFERENCES:

Christopher Coyne ccoyne3@gmu.edu
Department of Economics, George Mason University
Peter Boettke pboettke@gmu.edu
Department of Economics, George Mason University
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Robi Ragan ragan_ra@mercer.edu
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Jason Dunick (Teaching only) jdunick@gmu.edu
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